

Joseph Kotzker

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About me

I'm a senior software engineer at Example Media, working across the full stack with a focus on the backend systems and services behind a platform of tens of thousands of community sites and millions of users. Before that, I was a full-stack developer at Sample Events, building registration and fundraising tools for non-profits, and before that I spent nearly four years at Placeholder Labs building compliance software. I have a B.S. in Computer Science from State University.

Work experience

Senior Software Engineer, Example Media 2026-04 – present

- Core member of a small team on a platform-wide search overhaul, modernizing the search stack and index for AI-assisted search
- Take an active role in driving initiatives from design through delivery, with substantial collaboration across teams
- Use LLM-powered coding tools and agents extensively day to day, and build the workflows around them

Software Engineer II, Example Media 2023-01 – 2026-04

- Backend engineering for a large community platform under sustained high traffic
- Built and maintained Java and Spring Boot microservices, and led several framework migrations
- Developed queue-based, message-driven pipelines
- Worked across two public clouds and the company's own internal infrastructure
- Extended a mature platform carrying thousands of customizations, through first- and third-party extensions
- Built early AI- and LLM-powered user-facing features at scale, using retrieval-augmented generation
- Adopted agentic development and LLM-assisted coding tools early

Software Developer, Sample Events 2021-04 – 2022-12

- Full-stack development on a web platform for event registration and donations, in PHP and MySQL
- Led the ground-up rework of the platform's reporting features, and redesigned the donation flow

Senior Software Engineer, Placeholder Labs 2020-01 – 2021-03

- Developer and technical lead on a suite of compliance applications; led major redesigns of the audit trail and workflow engine
- Led the design of a configurable risk-analysis feature, and improved the CI review process

Associate Software Developer, Placeholder Labs 2017-06 – 2019-12

- Full-stack development on the company's primary cloud application, taking on a leadership role on several teams
- Built internal tooling to improve the development lifecycle

Intern, Sample Fax Co. 2016-05 – 2017-05

- Built VPN connections for remote Linux servers, and a Python service for barcodes scanned in the field

Skills

- **Languages:** strongest in Java, PHP and JavaScript (including Node.js); experience with Python and C
- **Backend:** Spring and Spring Boot, microservice architecture, and common Java libraries
- **Messaging:** message-driven systems and pipelines
- **Cloud:** two public clouds and internal infrastructure platforms
- **Search and AI:** AI-powered search, RAG and vector databases
- **AI-assisted development:** agentic coding workflows; development of agent skills, plugins and MCP integrations
- **Build and CI:** Jenkins, including scripted pipelines in Groovy; Gradle, Maven and Docker
- **Web:** modern HTML, CSS and JavaScript
- **Testing:** unit testing and mocking with JUnit and PHPUnit
- **Version control:** Git and GitHub, branching strategies and advanced Git usage
- **Systems:** Linux and Unix-like systems, shell scripting and the command line
- **Process:** Agile/Scrum, issue trackers, technical design documents
- **Spoken languages:** fluent in English and a second language

Education

B.S. in Computer Science, State University

2017-05

- Minors in Philosophy and History